BRAIN 14

Kratom

Leaf of a Southeast Asian tree (Mitragyna speciosa) with over 50 alkaloids, mainly mitragynine



CLASS	STUDIED FOR	HUMAN EVIDENCE	US STATUS
Plant extract	Pain tolerance, abuse potential	Small human studies	Not FDA approved

STUDIED FOR

- **Abuse potential** — HUMAN
- **Pain tolerance** — HUMAN
- **Attention** — HUMAN
- **Anxiety and sadness** — HUMAN

Few well-designed human studies. FDA says so. Controlled studies mostly tested safety, blood levels and abuse potential, not mood or anxiety treatment.

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

SMALL HUMAN
LEVEL 3 OF 5

- Small controlled safety and abuse studies
- Largest: 116 healthy adults, 15 daily doses
- No trials as a treatment for mood or anxiety

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Long-term safety
- Half-life in people
- Effects on mood or anxiety
- Product content

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Mitragynine, 7-OH → Mu-opioid receptor → Serotonin, others → Opioid-like effect

- **Mitragynine and 7-OH** bind mu-opioid receptors, as opioid drugs do (FDA)
- **7-OH** is more potent at that receptor than mitragynine and morphine
- **Mitragynine** also acts on serotonin, dopamine and kappa-opioid systems
- **In people,** doses of 3 g or more narrowed the pupils, an opioid-like effect

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE	ROUTES STUDIED
Not established in people	By mouth (leaf powder, drinks, pure mitragynine)
PHARMACOKINETICS	**SOLD AS**
Limited human data; 7-OH is also formed from mitragynine in the body	Unapproved products; FDA says not lawful as supplement or food
MONITORED IN TRIALS	**SPORT (WADA)**
Side effects, abuse-related effects, withdrawal, liver enzyme	Not named on the 2026 list; S0 status not stated

REGULATORY

FDA	Not approved; not lawful as supplement or food
DEA	Kratom not scheduled; 7-OH scheduling proposed
DEA	3 related compounds Schedule I since Aug 2026
WADA	Not named on the 2026 list

REFERENCES

1. FDA, FDA and Kratom, Dec 2025
2. DEA, Federal Register 2026-20943, 7-OH above a threshold, Oct 14, 2026
3. Ther Drug Monit, Huestis et al., kratom leaf in healthy adults, Oct 2026

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